

Microsoft's Kinect for Xbox 360 has redefined the way gamers interact with their gaming and entertainment console. Claimed to be one of the fastest selling gadgets in history, it takes gaming from individuals to the family.

Jaspreet Bindra, who spearheads Microsoft Entertainment & Devices Division in India, is responsible for strategy, operations and marketing and sales efforts for gaming (Xbox 360 and games) in addition to IT hardware products (like mice and keyboards) and home productivity software (Windows/Student Home Office) sales at retail.

Bindra speaks to Uma Bansal, executive editor at EFY, about console gaming in India, difference made by Kinect and way forward...

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“Gaming is emerging as the third pillar of entertainment”

How was the year 2010 for console gaming in India?

Year 2010 was perhaps the best year in terms of innovations in console gaming. It saw three big trends—move beyond core gamers to family, motion gaming and 3D. We saw a lot of innovations across these trends. The biggest innovation, however, was controllerless gaming with Kinect.

We brought Kinect and other innovations to India literally at the same time as they happened across the world. We launched Kinect in November. With this, we saw sales of Xbox 360 more than doubling between November and December last year. We also saw our market share, especially in large-format retail stores like Croma, going up to 65 per cent.

Why does the need arise for a gaming console when one has a PC for gaming?

There are four different kinds of gaming: mobile, browser (on the Web), PC and console. Console gaming is the ultimate form of gaming with the richest graphics, the best effects and immersive experience. We have seen in the market that people who do browser or mobile gaming are actually those who then move on to or upgrade to console gaming.

But there are not many games available for consoles...

PC games are very small games that can be made with very low investment from both time and money perspectives. Making a PC game costs thousands of rupees—in that range. Console gaming is like producing huge blockbusters. It's like producing a two-minute movie with your camera for YouTube versus creating an *Avatar*. You will see only a few *Avatars*. In console gaming, a good game like *Halo* costs tens of millions of dollars. So it's a different scale altogether. There will always be more mobile and PC games than console games as they are much less expensive to produce.

What will turn around console gaming in India?

India is still a very small gaming market comparatively. As per a NASSCOM-FICCI estimate, it's about \$300 million or Rs 12-13 billion in size. One-third to half of that is console gaming. In comparison, China is a \$6-billion gaming market. The US is estimated to be a \$15-20 billion market. And gaming globally is a \$45-billion market.

However, India is one of the fastest growing markets. And in the overall entertainment category in India (movies, TV and gaming), gaming is growing the fastest at about 35 per cent. Pretty much, gaming is emerging as the third pillar